Chapter 4

Introduction

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The texts of this part were written between 2009 and 2012 for a school book about plants that for various reasons could not be completed, but text excerpts have been integrated in the Multifunctional Teop English Dictionary (MTED) as "examples".[1] The following 10 chapters document that in the beginning of the 21st century local plants are still an essential resource for the production of artefacts or are at least remembered as such by elder speakers.

In the first chapter Joyce Maion describes the growth of the coconut palm and the use of its parts, which confirms Shoffner's statement (1976: 284) that the coconut palm "has the most diverse uses of any member of the Teop plant assemblage. Almost every part of this tree can be utilized."

The following chapters by Joyce Maion and Ruth Sima Rigamu deal with the sago palm, the Blackboard Tree, the young bread fruit tree, three kinds of bamboo, various plants that are used for making strings, and finally with three kinds of pandanus, see Table 1.

The bamboos described in Chapter 10 represent three distinct species called *koopu*, *koverau*, and *kururu* with distinct usages. There is no generic term for them in the Teop language.

Chapter 11 on "Vines, aerial roots, fibres and strings" deals in 14 subsections with plants, parts of plants, and strings that are formally classified as *kara*, e.g. *kara koris* 'vine', *kara kave* 'net vine', *kara ruhu* 'aerial root of the Bengal Ficus', and *kara obai* 'string made of the *obai* 'Sweet Flag' (*Acorus Calamus*)'. The word *kara* functions as the head of compounds and means 'sth. that is thin and long'.

[1] In Mosel (2019), search the Semantic Domain of the MTED for "plants" and the Parts of Speech for "N3" and "N3.CONSTR" and you will find 293 entries about plants and parts of plants.

Table 1: Plants and the artefacts produced from them

CHAP	PLANTS	ARTEFACTS
5	coconut palm	baskets, trays, brooms, strings, planting sticks
6	sago palm	thatch roof
7	blackboard tree	hull of dug-out canoes
8	young breadfruit tree	strings for tying fishing nets
9	sea poison tree	floats of fishing nets
10	bamboos	spears, water containers, containers for cooking, walls of dwelling houses, and strips for sewing the thatch roof
11	vines, aerial roots, fibres	strings for kite-fishing, strings for firmly lashing things together, straps for backpacks, and mats
12	hibiscus fibres	straps for backpacks, skirts for dancing
13	pandanus	mats, baskets, hats
14	giant pandanus	hoods

Imported plastic strings are called *kara sitiring* in contrast to *kara naono* ‘string made of local plant materials’.[2]

[2]Search the MTED Headword field for “kara” with a space after *kara* and find 33 entries.